

as if the Internet might force all traditional businesses to close their doors. It also looked as if small investments in staking out valuable Internet turf might turn into real gold mines. So the hustlers moved in—thousands of them. Each had a vision. And many were able to raise money to see their vision come—more or less—to life.

For the lucky among them, the vision still looked attractive after they had fleshed it out a bit. They were able to take their companies public, raising billions of dollars, even though the companies had never made a cent and no one was very sure how or when they might ever become profitable.

A few entrepreneurs were able to cash out and walk away with millions. But after the washout in 2000, most ended up with nothing. Either way, they were not building family wealth, at least not the way we recommend. They were making fast money—a big score.

We don't recommend that approach for two reasons. The first reason is obvious: It usually doesn't work. It's hard to make fast money. In fact, the fastest way to make money is to make it slowly. You can try to make it fast forever and never get anywhere. But try to make it slowly . . . keep at it . . . and you'll probably end up with at least something—eventually.

The other reason is that when you build your business fortune slowly, it is much more likely to last. Because you're not just trying to take advantage of dimwitted investors. You're actually trying to build a successful business. And successful businesses are built, as we've seen, by trial and error over a long period of time. As time goes by, you develop not only the capital you need but also the skills, experience, and knowledge needed to preserve it. The quick-hit entrepreneur, however, has only money. And money goes fast, especially when it is in the hands of someone who doesn't know much about it. What became of the Internet fortunes built by twenty-somethings in the 1990s? We don't know. Our guess is that they disappeared in the 2000s.

The Internet gave wealth creators a huge boost; it still does. But the way to take advantage of it was by trial and error, slowly discovering how to use it to build a real business. Instead of investing a fortune of other people's money in a vision, the successful wealth builder invests little bits of family money to learn something. Then, only when he has proven out his concept does he put down big money.